drive a critically ill patient to the hospital, and the fire brigade can stop a stray Shabbat candle from burning an entire neighborhood.

The state of Israel does not actually have a “Shabbat law”. It has a 1951 labor law, which stipulates that members of each faith are entitled to their traditional days of rest: Friday for Muslims, Sunday for Christians, and Shabbat for Jews. The state law also makes a wider class of exceptions for Shabbat than religious law does: it’s not just the emergency services that work as normal, but also things like hotels. Critical infrastructure is on the list, too. The electric company will repair downed power lines on a Saturday, and pharmacies set a rotating schedule to ensure the public can buy medicine. The laws on Shabbat observance, in other words, make accommodations for modern life.

A separate law passed in 1990 allows local authorities to impose their own Shabbat regulations. Most of Israel’s cities have rules, but when the Knesset surveyed the twenty-five largest cities in 2014, it found that thirteen—more than half—did not rigorously enforce them. Ramat Gan, a suburb of Tel Aviv with a bustling commercial center, handed out 142 fines for Shabbat violations in 2011. The following year it issued two. Either the business community had a sudden crisis of religious conscience, or authorities simply gave up applying the law. “It’s not possible for us to map the fines that were handed out by inspectors,” said officials in Petah Tikva, a sleepy central city with a largely non-Orthodox population.[18]

Confusing as it is, this arrangement works for cities with a distinct religious character. Secular Tel Aviv winks at the law but largely ignores it, deploying just four inspectors each weekend to patrol a city of 425,000 people; my neighborhood supermarket happily sells bacon on a Saturday morning. Adjacent Bnei Brak has seven qualified inspectors, all of whom stay home on Shabbat. The city is ultra-Orthodox, and nobody would think to desecrate the holy day. The problems arise where Israel’s secular and religious tribes rub shoulders.

The ultra-Orthodox don’t always win. A *haredi* man named Meir Cohen was briefly famous in 2015 for a series of YouTube videos he made at a shopping center in Ashdod, which does business on Shabbat. He would stand outside the mall and yell *Shabbat HaYom!* (“Today is the Sabbath!”) at passersby. Eventually the police got tired of him, and arrested him for harassment. The shopping center is still open. There was also the years-long saga of a humble parking lot in Jerusalem. In a bid to encourage tourism,